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MART120

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Week 2 Reflection- Last Lecture

Starting the week off with Randy Pausch's 2007 "Last Lecture" at Carnegie Mellon was great. It was eye-opening to listen to while reflecting. There's something special about how little self-pity is in the talk. He does push-ups on stage to prove he's still strong. He jokes about the absurdity of the situation. It would have been easy for him to make the lecture about grief. Instead, he treats his remaining time as something to spend deliberately, on the people and ideas that mattered to him. The idea that stuck with me most was Pausch's line about brick walls: "The brick walls are there for a reason. They're not there to keep us out. The brick walls are there to give us a chance to show how badly we want something." It reframes obstacles entirely. Instead of evidence you're on the wrong path, it acts as a filter that only stops the people who didn't want it badly enough. That's a much more useful way to think about setbacks than treating them as verdicts on whether you belong somewhere.

The second thing that stuck with me was the structure of the whole talk. Pausch spent the first half walking through his own childhood dreams: playing in the NFL, experiencing zero gravity, becoming a Disney Imagineer, and how he'd managed to achieve most of them, sometimes in unexpected ways. But by the end, he reveals the "head fake": the lecture was never really about achieving his dreams. It was about enabling the dreams of other people: his students as well as the two kids he wouldn't get to watch grow up.